

Estonian identity in the diaspora

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- Born and raised in Vancouver.
- Spoke Estonian at home, went to local Estonian School, participated in folk dance and theatre groups, attended community events, etc.
- Other than one year at Muhu Elementary School, attended elementary and high schools in Canada. Never completed sixth grade!
- One year at the University of Ottawa, otherwise studied Semiotics and Culture Studies at the University of Tartu.

- Estimated that there are about 200 000 people of Estonian origin worldwide, about 15% of all Estonians.
- Mostly fled during the Second World War. 1940: Molotov-Ribbentrop Pact signed between Nazi Germany and Soviet Union, annexation of Estonia.
- In the following repressions, deportations, and escapes, about 17% of its populations (180 000 people) felt a direct loss (Mart Laar).

- June 14th, 1941. Men, women, and children rounded up into cattle cars, sent to Siberia. Many died along the way, many others because of the harsh winters, and even more because of the harsh working conditions. About 10 000 people exiled on this day.
- March 25th, 1949. 20 000 people, or 3% of the Estonian population, exiled. The youngest recorded case was a nine-month old, while two babies were born on the cattle trains.
- These constitute acts of genocide against the Estonian people. Crimes against humanity.



Deportees injured in the Vorkuta mine in front of the Vorkuta hospital in Siberia 1956



Typical clay hut giving shelter to Estonians deported to Siberia, the Novosibirsk region 1950



Children deported together with their mother and whose father was imprisoned, 1952



A boy, deported as an infant in 1949, 10 years later with his father in the Novosibirsk region of Siberia (1958)



Deported Estonian women doing forestry work in Siberia, the Kirov region in the 1950s

- Estonians fled to Germany and Sweden, mostly, but also England and other places.
- After living in Displaced Persons camps, many went onwards to Canada, Australia, the United States, Brazil, etc. Many arrived by boat under the watchful eye of the Statue of Liberty.
- There were rumours that the Swedish government was going to return Estonians who had fled to the Soviet Union. My family moved once more, arriving in Halifax, and moving onwards to Vancouver.
- Only a few people left who were children and remember having to flee Estonia. No contact with family for years, and for some, never again.



- The Vancouver Estonian community. Long history of folk dance groups, choirs, sororities, fraternities, Guides, Scouts, congregations, cultural organizations, theatre groups, improv circles, Estonian schools, pensioners clubs, etc.
- Outside of Toronto, second-largest Estonian community in Canada.
- Currently represented by four major organizations: Estonian Church Foundation, Society for the Advancement of Estonian Studies in Canada, St. Peter's Estonian Evangelical Lutheran Church in Vancouver, Vancouver Estonian Society.

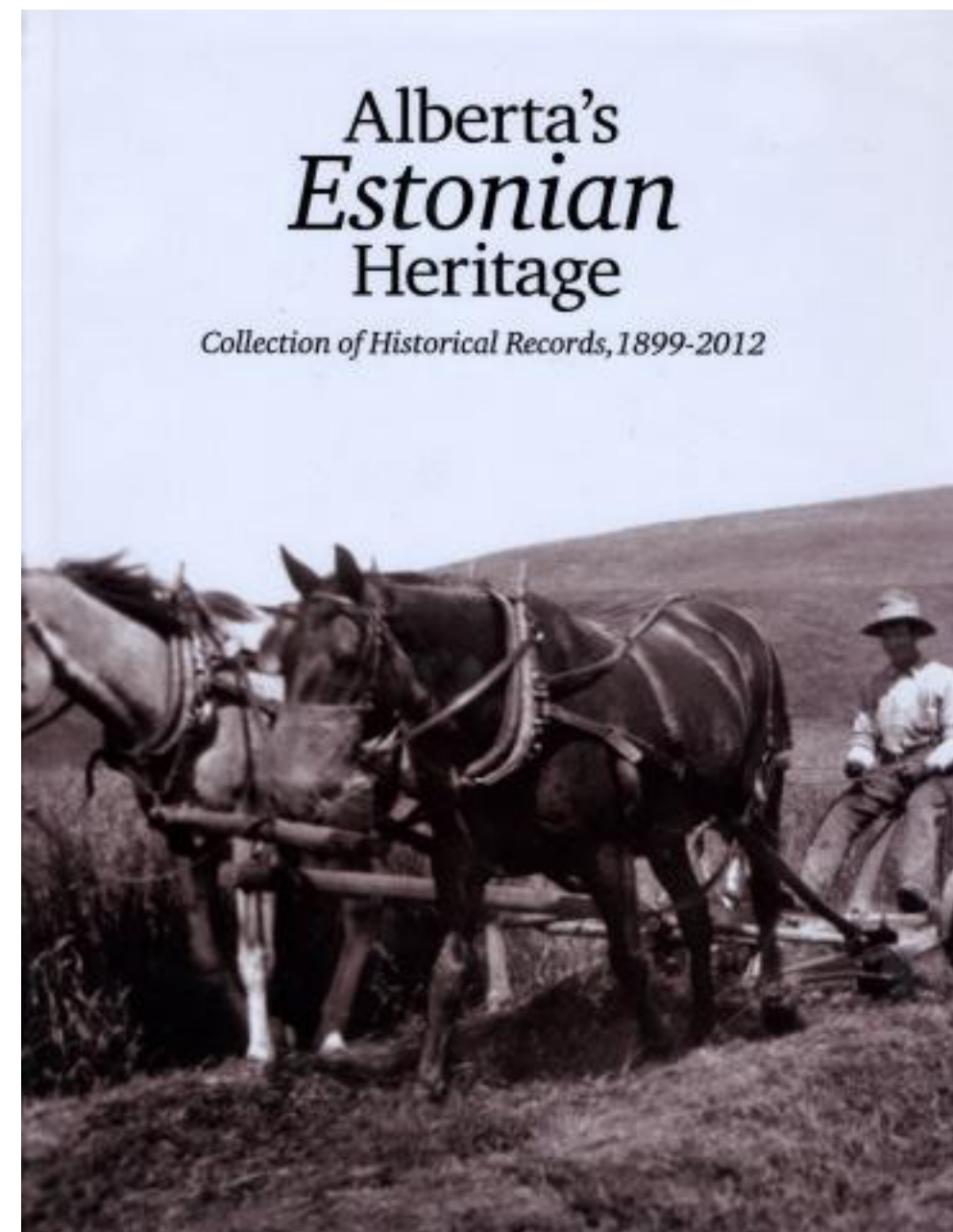
- ECF: responsible for Meie Kodu (“Our Home”), the community building and church.
- SAESC: responsible for the Estonian Archives Vancouver, the digitization of materials, the Binder of Tears, the Forest Lawn Memorial project, lectures, and more. Helped establish the Estonian chair at two local universities. Celebrate *emakeelepäev* (March 14th) and commemorate the deportations and escapes of June 14th 1941, September 1944, and March 25th 1944.
- Other groups: Pensioners’ Club who organize the Christmas market, Orthodox congregation closing their doors, etc.

- EELC: two services a month, one with communion. A Lutheran congregation with a Baptist minister and many Orthodox attendees. Community *kohvilaud* after every service; celebrating their 75th anniversary this month.
- VES: owner of Mäeotsa, 70 km outside of Vancouver. Organize Independence Day celebrations, *jaanipäev*, other events (Baltic Way, Black Ribbon Day, etc.). Publish *Läänekaare Postipoiss* for distribution in the community. Many sub-groups: the Vancouver Estonian Library, choirs, folk dance groups, Estonian School for children, etc.



- Probably about two to three thousand people with Estonian background in British Columbia.
- Probably about eight hundred to one thousand that truly identify with Estonia or as Estonians.
- Probably a couple of hundred that make up the Vancouver Estonian community.
- Probably a few dozen that make up the organizations and do the work within the community.

- “Estonian-Canadian” (“Canadian-Estonian”?) is not a homogeneous grouping.
- A Vancouver Estonian is different from an Alberta Estonian is different from a Toronto (and wider Ontario) Estonian.
- Complex differentiations even within small communities: “active” vs. “passive”, “*väliseestlane*” (“abroad-Estonian”) vs. “*kodueestlane*” (“home-Estonian”), “settler” vs. “refugee”, “communist” vs. “patriot”, etc.



Is every Estonian living abroad a
'väliseestlane'?

Estonians worldwide don't all agree on the term *väliseestlane* — literally "abroad-Estonian," but used to mean diaspora Estonian. Some identify strongly with it, while others find it alienating. Ultimately, it's best to ask diaspora members directly how they define themselves, linguist and researcher Mari-Liis Korkus said on Vikerraadio.

Väliseestlane is probably the most prevalent term used to describe members of Estonian communities abroad. *Väliseestlased*, in turn, are differentiated from *kodueestlased* — literally "home-Estonians," meaning Estonians in or from Estonia, depending on context. The term is by no means a new one; examples of its usage can be found dating back as far as even a century.

Other terms have been used alongside *väliseestlane* as well, including *ulgueestlane*, *hajalaeestlane* (diaspora Estonian), *globaalne* or *üleilmne eestlane* (global Estonian), *eestlane välismaal* (Estonian abroad) or *rahvuskaaslane* (compatriot).

More specific terms are used to describe particular communities as well. For example, members of the Canadian and Swedish diaspora may be referred to more specifically as *kanada-eestlased* (Canadian Estonians) or *rootsi-eestlased* (Swedish Estonians). Starting in 2011, the term *kalevipoeg* — referring to the title character of the Estonian national epic — also started being used to refer to construction workers commuting between Estonia and Finland.

pagulaseestlased — "refugee Estonians," referring to World War II-era refugees.

- Semiotics: the study of how human beings—and actually, all lifeforms or organisms—make meaning. All meaning is a product of signs.
- Estonia, especially Tartu, stands out globally.
- Writing the history of semiotics cannot be done responsibly without referencing its development in Estonia or by Estonians, while the intellectual history of Estonia cannot be responsibly written without referencing semiotics.
- Intertwined with Estonian cultural history; part of my own identity.

- For humans, what is more meaningful to us than our identities, whether individual or collective, linguistic or cultural, ethnic or racial, sexual or gender-based, sociological or subcultural, age- or vocation-based, mythological or historical, and so forth?
- The identity that human beings possess determines how they ascribe meaning to themselves, others, and the world at large. Therefore, the problem of identity seems to be a fundamental problem of semiotics.

- The surrounding universe of meaning, or *semiosphere*. Ex. Estonian semiosphere, Canadian semiosphere, the semiosphere of a novel, the semiosphere of this classroom. Static and dynamic aspects.
- Presence of different culture-specific “codes”: (1) traffic rules, (2) sauna etiquette, (3) sense of humour.
- Meaning-making as a highly-dynamic process. *Dialogical*. “Estonglish” as a model of the diasporic identity.

- Diasporic identity does not keep, for example, the Estonian and Canadian identities separate, “at arm’s length” from one another, but is constantly putting them into new relations, creating new meanings, “translating” across their languages and cultures, “creolizing” into new structures.
- Diasporic identities are constantly being renewed in processes that involve creativity and normativity, descriptions and self-descriptions, and other internal and external factors.

Aitäh!